

ASSAM

The Assam region of India benefits from rich soil and monsoon rains, making it the most productive tea-growing region in the world. Characterized by deep, bold flavors, Assam tea makes up approximately 50 percent of India's total output of tea.

Located in the northeast corner of India on the low-lying alluvial flood plains of the Brahmaputra River Valley, Assam is a prime region for tea cultivation and produces mostly commodity tea using the CTC method (see p21) for the tea bag industry.

The rich soil is fed by floods during the monsoon season (May–October), and tea is picked from April to November, during the hottest and wettest season. Temperatures can reach 100°F (38°C) at this time of the year, simulating the conditions in a terrarium or green house. First flush Assam tea is harvested in April, while the second flush is picked from May to June and

is most often used in black tea blends, such as East Frisian or afternoon blends. Some growers are turning to orthodox production (see p21) to create high-grade whole leaf for export at a higher price than commodity tea. As such, orthodox Assam tea is protected under Geographical Indication, which ensures that all tea carrying the name “Assam” has come from this region.

The Assam region operates on a different time from the rest of India—“Bagan Time,” or “Tea Garden Time,” sees clocks set one hour ahead of IST (Indian Standard Time), allowing workers to take advantage of an early sunrise.

BRAHMAPUTRA RIVER VALLEY

The Brahmaputra River runs the full length of the state of Assam. This river valley is divided into four main tea-growing regions—Upper Assam, North Bank, Central Assam, and Lower Assam.



ASSAM KEY FACTS

PERCENTAGE
OF WORLD
PRODUCTION:

13%

MAIN TYPES:

**BLACK CTC,
ORTHODOX BLACKS,
GREEN**

HARVEST:

APRIL–NOVEMBER

FAMOUS FOR:

**BEING THE MOST PRODUCTIVE TEA-
GROWING REGION IN THE WORLD**

ELEVATION:

LOW